Unit 1 self-study guide

Level: C1 / advanced · **Theme:** identity, personality, images, and memories

Learning goals

By the end of the unit, you should be able to discuss names and identity, choose continuous forms for specific meanings, describe present and past habits, speculate tactfully, use vague language naturally, and write a personal profile and a description of a treasured object.

1.1 What's in a name?

Vocabulary: names and reputation

Expression	Meaning	New example
be named after someone	receive their name in someone's honor	I was named after my uncle.
live up to your name	meet the expectations created by your reputation	She is trying to live up to the family name.
make a name for yourself	become well known for an achievement	He made a name for himself as a designer.
a household name	a person known by many people	The singer is now a household name.
put your name forward	volunteer or apply	I put my name forward for class representative.
clear your name	prove you did nothing wrong	The evidence cleared her name.
by name	using a person's name	The manager knows everyone by name.
in name only	possessing a title without real power	He was director in name only.
maiden name	surname used before marriage	Her maiden name was Smith.

Discussion prompts: Can a name affect a first impression? Why might people change their names? How would you respond if someone repeatedly mispronounced your name?

Grammar: the continuous aspect

Form: a form of *be* + verb-*ing*. Perfect continuous forms add *been*: *has been working*, *had been waiting*, *will have been living*.

Meaning	Example	Why continuous?
action in progress	I'm reading the article now.	The action is unfinished.
temporary situation	She's staying with friends this month.	It is not permanent.
change in progress	The neighborhood is becoming more diverse.	The situation is developing.
background event	I was cooking when she called.	One action was underway when another happened.

Meaning	Example	Why continuous?
duration up to now	I've been studying for two hours.	The time spent matters.
repeated behavior, often irritating	He's always interrupting me.	The speaker expresses a reaction.
tentative idea or request	I was wondering whether you could help.	It sounds less direct.
uncertain plan	I was thinking of joining a class.	The plan is not final.

State verbs such as *own, belong, know,* and *want* normally use simple forms: *She owns the house*, not *She is owning the house*. Some verbs change meaning: *I think you're right* (opinion), but *I'm thinking about the question* (mental activity). *The soup tastes salty* describes a quality; *The chef is tasting the soup* describes an action.

Contrast: *I have written three pages* emphasizes the result. *I have been writing for an hour* emphasizes the activity and its duration.

1.2 What are you like?

Describing habits

Present	Past	Nuance
I tend to check details.	I used to check every detail.	A typical tendency / former habit.
She'll call before dinner.	She would call before dinner.	Characteristic repeated behavior.
He keeps asking questions.	He kept asking questions.	Repetition, often irritating.
She's always correcting me.	She was always correcting me.	Repetition with speaker attitude.
I'm prone to overthinking.	I was prone to overthinking.	A tendency, often undesirable.

Use *used to* for past states and habits: *I used to be shy*. Use *would* for repeated past actions, usually after the past context is clear: *When I was a child, I would read for hours*. Do not use habitual *would* for a state: *I would be shy* does not mean *I used to be shy*.

Useful expressions: *have a tendency to + infinitive*; *be inclined to + infinitive*; *be prone to + noun/-ing*; *as a rule*; *nine times out of ten*; *spend hours + -ing*.

Personality vocabulary and idioms

Opposites: *considerate / selfish; circumspect / impetuous; conservative / liberal; temperamental / easy-going; gregarious / introverted*. Use personality labels carefully and give evidence: "She seems circumspect because she asks questions before making a decision."

Idioms: *a yes-man* (agrees with authority), *a whiz kid* (very talented young person), *a busybody* (meddles), *a chatterbox* (talks constantly), *a pain in the neck* (annoying person), *a dark horse* (someone with unexpected abilities), *an old hand* (experienced person), *set in your ways* (resistant to change), *the black sheep* (family member seen as different or disapproved of), *the life and soul of the party* (person who makes a gathering lively).

Speaking prompt: Which habits help you learn English? Which habit would you like to change? Support each answer with a specific example.

1.3 Picture perfect

Speculating with appropriate certainty

- Low certainty: *She might be an artist. It could be a studio.*
- Moderate certainty: *I'd say she's in her thirties. It looks as if she's waiting for someone.*
- Evidence-based inference: *She gives the impression of being confident because of her posture.*
- Stronger, but still cautious: *I'm pretty sure this is a family photograph.*

Avoid treating an impression as fact. Say *"He looks as though he might be tired"* rather than making an unsupported claim about his personality.

Vague language in conversation

A couple of things, a bit of time, around fifty, fifty or so, sort of, kind of, and so on, and *or something like that* make informal speech approximate. Use them when precision is unnecessary. Avoid contradictions such as *exactly eight-ish*. *Stuff* is normally uncountable: *a lot of stuff*, not *stuffs*.

Pronunciation practice: Say *a couple of things* as one smooth phrase. Notice how unstressed auxiliaries in *I've been working* become shorter. Listen to authentic audio before judging your own pronunciation.

1.4 Francesco's Venice

Describing a treasured object

Organize the description into four parts: (1) what it is and where it came from; (2) its physical details; (3) a specific memory; (4) why it matters now. Useful words: *inherit, bequeath, hand down, heirloom, sentimental value, treasure*.

Model paragraph (original): "My grandfather gave me a small wooden chessboard when I was twelve. Its corners are worn, and one square has a faint coffee stain. We used to play on Sunday afternoons while he told stories about his childhood. I still keep it on my desk. It has little monetary value, but it reminds me to slow down and make time for people."

Writing: a personal profile

Plan for the audience. A class profile can sound warm and personal; a professional profile should foreground work, skills, and relevant achievements. Use concrete details, a clear order, and an honest tone.

Suggested structure (150–200 words): introduction and background; interests and skills; one meaningful example; current goal. After drafting, check verb forms, articles, punctuation, and word count.

Seven-day independent plan

Day	Focus	Output
1	Names and vocabulary	Explain five expressions in your own words.
2	Continuous aspect	Complete practice A and explain each choice.
3	Habits and personality	Record a two-minute description of your habits.
4	Speculation and vague language	Describe a photograph without overclaiming.
5	Profile writing	Draft and revise 150–200 words.
6	Objects and memories	Write 120–160 words about an object.
7	Retrieval and review	Redo missed exercises without notes.

Mastery checklist

- [ ] I can explain why a continuous form is used, not just form it.
- [ ] I can distinguish *used to* from habitual *would*.
- [ ] I can describe a habit with at least three natural structures.
- [ ] I can hedge a speculation and support it with evidence.
- [ ] I can use name expressions and personality idioms appropriately.
- [ ] I can write a coherent profile and object description for their audience.
- [ ] I can identify what needs audio/video evidence instead of guessing.

Original practice — Unit 1

Complete the tasks without looking at the key. Write full sentences where possible.

A. Continuous aspect

Choose the most natural form and explain the meaning.

1. I **think / am thinking** about changing my surname.
2. This apartment **belongs / is belonging** to my cousin.
3. When I arrived, Maya **wrote / was writing** her profile.
4. We **have waited / have been waiting** for your reply all morning; please call us.
5. He **always interrupts / is always interrupting** me, and it drives me mad.
6. By December, I **will have lived / will have been living** here for ten years. Use the option that emphasizes duration.
7. I **wondered / was wondering** if you could review my draft. Use the more tentative form.
8. The number of people using two first names **grows / is growing** rapidly.

B. Habit structures

Rewrite each sentence with the prompt. Keep the meaning.

1. When I was younger, I read for hours every evening. (*would*)
2. I was shy in primary school, but I am not shy now. (*used to*)
3. She repeatedly checks her phone during meals, which annoys me. (*always*)
4. I often make a plan before I begin writing. (*tend*)
5. He regularly forgets people's names. (*prone*)
6. They continued to complain, despite our explanation. (*kept*)

C. Vocabulary and collocations

Fill each gap with one expression from this box, changing its form if necessary: *named after; household name; clear her name; put his name forward; in name only; old hand; dark horse; set in his ways*.

1. He volunteered to lead the debate: he _____.
2. She proved the allegation was false and managed to _____.
3. The director has no authority; she is a director _____.
4. Nobody knew he could sing opera. He is a _____.
5. After twenty years in the job, Rosa is an _____.
6. The actor became a _____ after the series was released.
7. He refuses to try any new software; he is _____.
8. My parents gave me my grandmother's name, so I was _____ her.

D. Speculation and vague language

Rewrite these claims more carefully, using the prompt.

1. “She is a photographer.” (*might; camera*)
2. “He is angry.” (*gives the impression; expression*)
3. “Exactly forty people attended.” You only have an estimate. (*about*)

4. “I have two things to discuss.” Make it casual. (*a couple of*)
5. “He is definitely a teacher.” You only saw a classroom in the background. (*It looks as if*)

Correct the errors.

1. We have a plenty of time.
2. I bought a couple books.
3. She has many stuffs in her bag.
4. Let's meet at exactly nine-ish.

E. Reading and critical thinking

The article about names presents conflicting research findings. Answer in 2–3 sentences each.

1. Why should we avoid claiming that a first name *always* determines job opportunities?
2. What other factors could explain different callback rates in hiring studies?
3. How can you discuss name-based bias without endorsing stereotypes?

F. Speaking tasks

1. **Names (2 minutes):** Explain your name, any nickname, and whether names shape first impressions.
2. **Habits (2 minutes):** Describe two current learning habits and one habit you had as a child. Use *tend to, keep + -ing,* and *used to* or *would*.
3. **Photo (90 seconds):** Describe a portrait. Make three evidence-based speculations with different degrees of certainty and one natural vague expression.

Record yourself. Listen once for meaning, once for grammar, and once for pronunciation. Note one improvement, then record again.

G. Writing tasks

1. **Personal profile (150–200 words):** Write for a class website. Include background, interests, a specific achievement or experience, and a current goal.
2. **Treasured object (120–160 words):** Describe its origin, physical features, one memory, and its value to you. Include one continuous form and one past-habit structure.

Self-check rubric (0–2 points each): clear organization; accurate grammar; varied vocabulary; specific supporting details; appropriate tone. A score of 8–10 means the draft is ready for detailed feedback; a lower score shows what to revise first.

Original practice — answer key

A. Continuous aspect

1. **am thinking** — an active process of considering a change.
2. **belongs** — a state verb expressing ownership.
3. **was writing** — an action in progress when another action happened.
4. **have been waiting** — emphasizes the duration of the wait.
5. **is always interrupting** — repeated action plus irritation.
6. **will have been living** — duration up to a future point.
7. **was wondering** — a tentative, polite request.
8. **is growing** — change in progress.

B. Habit structures

1. When I was younger, I **would read** for hours every evening.
2. I **used to be** shy in primary school.
3. She **is always checking** her phone during meals.
4. I **tend to make** a plan before I begin writing.
5. He **is prone to forgetting** people's names.
6. They **kept complaining**, despite our explanation.

C. Vocabulary and collocations

1. put his name forward; 2. clear her name; 3. in name only; 4. dark horse; 5. old hand; 6. household name; 7. set in his ways; 8. named after.

D. Speculation and vague language

1. She **might be** a photographer; she's carrying a professional-looking camera.
2. He **gives the impression of being** angry because of his expression.
3. **About forty** people attended.
4. I have **a couple of things** to discuss.
5. **It looks as if** he might be a teacher; there's a classroom behind him.
6. We have **plenty of** time.
7. I bought **a couple of** books.
8. She has **a lot of stuff** in her bag.
9. Let's meet at **about nine** or **nine-ish**.

E. Reading and critical thinking — model points

1. The article itself reports conflicting results across studies. A callback difference in one study does not prove a universal rule or show that a name alone caused the difference in every setting.
2. The employer pool, job type, location, applicant details, sample size, and how names are perceived could affect results. A well-designed study would control as many of these factors as possible.
3. Describe the observed bias as a problem in the evaluator's response, not a trait of the applicant. Use qualified language and avoid making claims about individuals based on a name.

F–G. Speaking and writing

These require personal answers. Check that the speaking responses use the requested structures naturally and tie speculation to visible evidence. For writing, verify the requested length, organization, tone, and grammar. Send a draft or recording transcript to your tutor for line-by-line feedback.